

Listening at Scale

An operational diagnostic designed and delivered in weeks, not months.

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THE CHALLENGE

A national fundraising agency, roughly 1,000 people across multiple client verticals, mid-integration after several acquisitions, needed candid workflow analysis from across the organization. Not just the executive bench. Not just one vertical. The traditional path is a consulting team on-site for weeks, a six-figure invoice, and stacks of raw transcripts to synthesize at the end. Brenna and SherpaTech.AI proposed a different path. SherpaTech had already built and proven a confidential AI voice interview agent. Brenna saw the fit and pitched it to leadership: hear from 25 to 30 stakeholders candidly, on a budget and timeline that wouldn't bend the engagement out of shape.

THE APPROACH

The Agent, nicknamed BANANA, is a confidential AI voice interview agent. Participants called a dedicated number on their own schedule, from anywhere, and worked through a 45-minute conversational interview. They could pause for a meeting and resume the conversation later. The Agent was introduced as "Brenna's AI assistant," in the invitation email and again when she started the call (the Agent's voice is female-coded). The personal-assistant framing signals a confidential conversation. Corporate framing signals an audit. Each completed interview produced a 22-field structured record (role, vertical, friction points, verbatim quotes, AI openness, risk flags) landing in an analyzable dataset within minutes.

WHAT MADE IT DIFFERENT

The most striking moment came mid-engagement. A senior member of the agency's leadership joined a call unscripted. He wasn't on the original interview list. His questions and posture were unmistakably executive: different cadence, different vocabulary, different concerns. Without being told to, the agent recognized the shift and reframed its questions in an executive register.

"I was really impressed with how well the agent changed the phrasing of the questions to be relevant to a C-suite person, even though they weren't originally designed for that. She very much responded to what he was putting out there instead of following a script. Which was exactly what we want."

The other discipline that mattered was keeping each call on signal. Honest interviews drift toward venting; the relief of being heard turns into a release, and the priority intelligence gets buried. The Agent was designed to honor what people needed to say while staying on the priority questions.

"She, the agent, did a really good job at always kind of bringing it back to the core of the questionnaire instead of just a venting session, which is hard for a human to do."

THE OUTCOME

Deadline met. Interview phase compressed from weeks to days. All six priority signals surfaced, plus bright spots. The data came back quantitatively richer (22 structured fields per call) and qualitatively deeper (participants said things they wouldn't have said face-to-face), at roughly 20% of what a traditional consulting-team engagement at this scale would have cost.

FROM SHERPATECH

The Agent is a confidential AI interview agent built on best-in-class speech and LLM infrastructure with a structured-extraction layer. Each conversation produces 22 fields of analyzable signal in minutes.

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Persona. Warm, curious, non-judgmental. "Brenna's AI assistant," not an auditor, not a manager, not a leadership representative.

Pacing built for candor. Seven-minute warm-up, twenty-eight-minute core, ten-minute warning, structured close.

Six priority signals. Shadow processes, error and rework culture, cross-team friction, leadership-versus-reality gap, technology handoffs, AI openness.

Sensitive topics, interviewee-led. Acknowledge without probing. Offer the engagement lead for direct follow-up. Hard escalation criteria for self-harm, illegal activity, or harassment trigger termination and notification.

Names redirect to process. When a colleague is named inside a complaint, the agent moves to workflow questions, not deeper into the interpersonal.

WHO IT'S FOR

Consultants running operational diagnostics, including stakeholder interviews, workflow assessments, and organizational listening. Associations with low survey response rates. Nonprofits that need candid donor or member voice without a six-figure research engagement.